from, first, Germany, then Japan and more recently China have repeatedly been read off as constituting challenges to American hegemony. And US military interventions are often still seen as assertions of a 'territorial logic' of empire along the old lines and/or as compensating for the decline of US economic power which international economic competitiveness has been taken to represent.[6]

In fact, what has characterised relations among the major capitalist states – as their response to the global economic crisis of the 1970s already showed, and is again being confirmed in the current crisis – is not a temporary and fleeting condominium among their capitalist classes such as Kautsky, much to Lenin's ire, predicted might emerge after World War I, but rather a much deeper integration. This has been marked by international networks of integrated production; the centrality of the dollar and US Treasury bonds in international trade and capital flows, with Wall Street and its satellite in London as the preeminent international financial centres; and the common elaboration of domestic, commercial and international law very much modelled along US lines, but above all designed to guarantee that foreign capital would be treated the same as domestic capital.

While this does not efface economic competition between various centres of accumulation, it does largely efface the interest and capacity of each 'national bourgeoisie' to act as the kind of coherent force directed to challenging the informal American empire, not least because they see it as the ultimate guarantor of capitalist interests globally. And while the imperial role of the American state internationally certainly has encompassed the representation of its capitalists' interests abroad, the US 'national interest' has come to be defined in terms of more fundamental concerns with the extension and defence of global capitalism.

The integration of a good many major states in the Global South over the last quarter of the century into global capitalism, often through the crucible of economic crises, has extended but also complicated the imperial responsibilities of the American state. Yet to always search for the rationale for US military interventions in either the old logic of territorial expansion or the assertion of the specific interests of some fraction of American capital remains an all too common mistake. Rather, it is important to see that the same logic of sustaining and expanding the conditions for a global capitalism that originally underlay the development and maintenance of overwhelming US military power has left the American state with the burden of deploying that power in the face of such morbid symptoms as uneven capitalist development produces.

US military interventions abroad are best understood in a manner quite analogous to what police forces at home have done in 'restoring order' when the divisions of race and class have blown up into open conflicts in American cities,